ROALLA



EXECUTIVE AI READINESS AND GOVERNANCE GUIDE

AI Readiness and Governance Guide 2026

A decision framework for deploying artificial intelligence safely, economically and at scale

Prepared for Canadian founders, chief executives, technology, product, data, risk and privacy leaders

Prepared by ROALLA Transformation and Technology Advisory

Status date: 6 October 2026

Purpose

This guide helps management determine whether the organization, a proposed AI use case and its operating controls are ready for responsible deployment. It connects commercial value, data, architecture, delivery capacity and governance so that AI investments advance through evidence rather than enthusiasm.

EXECUTIVE DECISION DASHBOARD

Management View at a Glance

Management should authorize AI investment only when a bounded use case has a measurable outcome, lawful and reliable data, an accountable owner, fit-for-purpose architecture, defined human oversight and an operating model for monitoring performance and risk.

Executive question	ROALLA view	Decision implication
Is AI strategically justified?	**CONDITIONAL**	Confirm a measurable business outcome and accountable executive sponsor.
Is the data foundation credible?	**PREPARE**	Validate lawful access, quality, lineage, retention and residency before model selection.
Can the organization control AI risk?	**CONDITIONAL**	Establish risk classification, human oversight, evaluation and incident response.
Should the organization scale now?	**DECIDE**	Advance only after a controlled pilot meets value, quality, safety and adoption thresholds.
What should management authorize?	**PURSUE**	A 90-day readiness diagnostic and one governed flagship use case.

Recommended Management Posture

Proceed through a small number of explicit decision gates. Preserve evidence as work occurs, separate discovery from implementation, and require each investment to demonstrate value, feasibility, control effectiveness and accountable ownership before scale.

EXECUTIVE DECISION MODEL

The Eight AI Readiness Gates

An AI initiative is investment-ready only when business value and delivery feasibility are supported by evidence and governance. A failed hard gate changes the decision from pursue to prepare, regardless of executive excitement.

Stage	Gate	Required conclusion	Decision evidence
01	Strategy	Material business or customer problem	Approved outcome hypothesis and executive sponsor
02	Use case	Bounded workflow and decision rights	Process map, users, exceptions and success criteria
03	Data	Lawful, available and fit-for-purpose inputs	Data inventory, quality profile and authority
04	Architecture	Secure integration and operating design	Target architecture, interfaces and controls
05	Model	Fit, limitations and evaluation standard	Model card, benchmarks and acceptance thresholds
06	Risk	Privacy, security, fairness and safety	Impact assessment, mitigations and escalation path
07	Adoption	Human oversight and change readiness	Training, workflow design and adoption measures
08	Operations	Monitoring, ownership and lifecycle funding	Service levels, telemetry, review and exit plan

Decision Rule

A failed hard gate moves the initiative to Prepare or Monitor. A strong narrative, senior sponsor or attractive market cannot replace missing authority, evidence, delivery capacity or operating control.

SECTION 01

Readiness Framework

Translate ambition into a shared executive view of value, evidence, capability and risk.



Readiness Dimensions

Dimension	Decision area	Management evidence	Status
01	Business value	Outcome, baseline, owner and economic case	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
02	Data	Authority, quality, lineage, access and retention	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
03	Technology	Integration, model, cloud, security and observability	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
04	Governance	Policy, classification, approvals and evidence	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
05	People	Accountability, skills, oversight and adoption	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
06	Operations	Monitoring, incidents, change, cost and retirement	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**

Evidence Standard

Assessments should distinguish verified evidence from management confidence. Where evidence is incomplete, record the gap, owner, completion date and decision that depends on it.

STRATEGIC READINESS DEPENDENCIES

What Readiness Depends On

Dependency	Why it matters	Evidence management should expect
Strategy	Material business or customer problem	Approved outcome hypothesis and executive sponsor
Use case	Bounded workflow and decision rights	Process map, users, exceptions and success criteria
Data	Lawful, available and fit-for-purpose inputs	Data inventory, quality profile and authority
Architecture	Secure integration and operating design	Target architecture, interfaces and controls
Model	Fit, limitations and evaluation standard	Model card, benchmarks and acceptance thresholds
Risk	Privacy, security, fairness and safety	Impact assessment, mitigations and escalation path
Adoption	Human oversight and change readiness	Training, workflow design and adoption measures
Operations	Monitoring, ownership and lifecycle funding	Service levels, telemetry, review and exit plan

ROALLA Interpretation

Dependencies should be evaluated as a connected system. A weakness in ownership, data, architecture, delivery or governance can change the economics and risk of an otherwise attractive initiative.

SECTION 02

Detailed Readiness Assessment

Convert executive intent into verifiable requirements, accountable evidence and clear remediation actions.



READINESS CHECKLIST

Enterprise AI Foundation

Completion standard Mark Ready only when the supporting evidence has been verified. Assign an evidence owner to every open item.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
A01	An executive sponsor owns the AI portfolio and its business outcomes.	☐	☐	_____
A02	A current inventory identifies internally developed, purchased and embedded AI systems.	☐	☐	_____
A03	AI use cases are classified by impact, data sensitivity and degree of autonomy.	☐	☐	_____
A04	The organization has approved AI principles, acceptable-use rules and escalation paths.	☐	☐	_____
A05	Data ownership, legal authority, residency, retention and deletion requirements are documented.	☐	☐	_____
A06	Privacy, security and procurement teams participate before technology commitments are made.	☐	☐	_____
A07	Approved model, platform and vendor patterns are defined with documented exceptions.	☐	☐	_____
A08	AI literacy and role-specific training are planned for executives, builders, operators and users.	☐	☐	_____
A09	A central evidence register captures decisions, tests, limitations, approvals and incidents.	☐	☐	_____
A10	Portfolio reviews measure value, risk, adoption, cost and lifecycle status at a defined cadence.	☐	☐	_____

READINESS CHECKLIST CONTINUED

AI Use Case and Control Readiness

Completion standard Use Gap to create a dated remediation action and identify the management decision that cannot proceed.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
B01	The use case solves a defined workflow problem and has a measurable baseline.	☐	☐	_____
B02	Users, affected parties, decision rights and human-oversight responsibilities are documented.	☐	☐	_____
B03	Training, reference and production data are representative, authorized and quality-tested.	☐	☐	_____
B04	Model and vendor choices are supported by evaluation results, limitations and fallback options.	☐	☐	_____
B05	Accuracy, reliability, bias, privacy, security and misuse tests have acceptance thresholds.	☐	☐	_____
B06	The solution logs inputs, outputs, overrides, errors, costs and material operating events.	☐	☐	_____
B07	High-impact outputs receive appropriate review before action is taken.	☐	☐	_____
B08	The pilot includes adoption measures, customer feedback and a defined stop condition.	☐	☐	_____
B09	Incident response covers harmful output, data leakage, model failure and vendor disruption.	☐	☐	_____
B10	Production approval includes monitoring, retraining, change control and retirement ownership.	☐	☐	_____

WEIGHTED EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Readiness Scorecard

Dimension	Weight	Evidence standard	Score	Status
Business value	20%	Outcome, baseline, owner and economic case	__/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
Data	20%	Authority, quality, lineage, access and retention	__/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
Technology	15%	Integration, model, cloud, security and observability	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Governance	15%	Policy, classification, approvals and evidence	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
People	15%	Accountability, skills, oversight and adoption	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Operations	15%	Monitoring, incidents, change, cost and retirement	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
TOTAL	100%	Weighted executive assessment	__/100	Pursue / Prepare / Monitor

Decision Thresholds

Score	Posture	Management decision
75 to 100	**PURSUE**	Proceed to bounded execution subject to no hard-gate failure.
50 to 74	**PREPARE**	Complete a focused readiness plan before major commitment.
0 to 49	**MONITOR**	Resolve foundational gaps before investing further.

A single material hard-gate failure overrides the weighted score. ROALLA also applies judgment where administrative readiness is high but strategic value, adoption or commercial viability is weak.

SECTION 03

Execution and Advisory Roadmap

Sequence decisions, evidence and delivery so management can invest with confidence and stop weak initiatives early.



READINESS OPERATING PLAN

Recommended 90 Day Mobilization

Timing	Focus	Key activities	Management output
Days 1 to 15	Mobilize	Confirm sponsor, scope, decision rights, evidence request and priority outcomes.	Approved mandate and fact base
Days 16 to 35	Assess	Review current evidence, interview owners, score readiness and identify hard gates.	Verified gaps and risk view
Days 36 to 55	Design	Define target operating, architecture, control and delivery options with economics.	Decision-ready options
Days 56 to 75	Validate	Test assumptions with users, data, technology, vendors and accountable control owners.	Evidence-backed recommendation
Days 76 to 90	Authorize	Approve the roadmap, owners, funding, measures, next gate and stop conditions.	Executive investment decision

Twelve to Twenty Four Month Path

- Quarter 1: establish the fact base, governance and one bounded priority initiative.
- Quarter 2: prove value and control effectiveness in a production-relevant pilot.
- Quarters 3 and 4: scale reusable capabilities, operating ownership and benefits realization.
- Year 2: optimize economics, institutionalize governance and refresh the portfolio using measured results.

How ROALLA Can Help

ROALLA acts as the technology and commercialization advisor coordinating strategy, evidence, architecture, governance, partners and executive decisions. The objective is not to maximize activity. It is to direct management effort toward investments that are valuable, controllable and executable.

ROALLA workstream	Executive value
Executive diagnostic	Establish the current fact base, hard gates, readiness score and management decisions.
Strategy and portfolio	Translate corporate priorities into a bounded, sequenced investment portfolio.
Architecture and data	Define target capabilities, integration, data, model, cloud and operating patterns.
Governance and risk	Design decision rights, policies, evidence, controls, monitoring and escalation.
Commercial and financial case	Model customer value, productivity, cost, funding, timing and benefits realization.
Vendor and partner ecosystem	Structure evaluation, sourcing, research, delivery and commercial relationships.
Execution readiness	Build roadmaps, work plans, budgets, measures, owners and decision gates.
Ongoing assurance	Monitor the portfolio, challenge evidence and bring decision-ready options to leadership.

Recommended Initial Mandate

- Four-week executive readiness diagnostic using this guide.
- Prioritized decision and evidence map with Pursue, Prepare and Monitor recommendations.
- One flagship initiative dossier with roadmap, economics, architecture and control plan.
- Executive readout and 90-day mobilization plan with accountable owners.

CONTROL FRAMEWORK

Key Risks and Controls

Risk	Exposure	ROALLA control
Value	AI is deployed without a material outcome.	Require an outcome owner, baseline and benefits case.
Data	Inputs are unlawful, poor quality or unrepresentative.	Validate authority, lineage, quality and minimization.
Model	Performance degrades outside the test context.	Define evaluations, thresholds, monitoring and fallback.
Privacy	Personal information is used or inferred improperly.	Complete privacy review and control collection, use and retention.
Security	Prompts, models, tools or integrations expose assets.	Threat-model the solution and restrict identities, tools and data.
Human oversight	Users over-rely on automated outputs.	Design meaningful review, override and escalation.
Vendor	Lock-in or service change undermines operations.	Assess portability, contracts, continuity and exit.
Cost	Usage and support costs exceed the business case.	Instrument unit economics and enforce cost guardrails.

Professional Advice

Qualified legal, privacy, security, tax, accounting, employment and regulatory advisors should validate matters within their professional scope. ROALLA coordinates those inputs with technology strategy, architecture, commercialization, governance and transformation decisions.

OFFICIAL EVIDENCE BASE

Selected Official Sources

These sources support the management principles summarized in this guide. Standards, laws, guidance and organizational obligations continue to evolve and must be confirmed for the specific context before acting.

NIST AI Risk Management Framework. Official source — Voluntary framework for governing, mapping, measuring and managing AI risk.
NIST Generative AI Profile. Official source — Companion risk profile for generative AI systems and use cases.
ISO IEC 42001 AI management systems. Official source — Management-system approach for responsible AI governance and continual improvement.
Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada AI guidance. Official source — Canadian privacy guidance for organizations developing or using AI.
Canadian privacy principles for generative AI. Official source — Privacy principles for development, provision and use of generative AI.
Government of Canada Digital Standards. Official source — User-centred, secure, accessible and iterative digital-service principles.

Advisory Disclaimer

This ROALLA guide is a strategic readiness and marketing document. It is not a certification, audit opinion, legal opinion, privacy opinion, security assurance, investment recommendation or guarantee of results. Management must validate current obligations, company facts and professional advice before making material decisions.